

SOCIAL INCLUSION AND BELONGING: AFFIRMING VALIDATION, AGENCY AND VOICE

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ABSTRACT

Social inclusion incorporates attitudes, expectations and perceptions about what it means to belong to a group. Belonging is embedded in personal beliefs and social structures that set forth criteria that determine how individuals and groups are accorded value and esteem. This chapter explores the constructs of social inclusion, exclusion and belonging with regard to persons in general and more specifically children with disability. It examines the importance of belonging and social inclusion to academic and psychosocial well-being and the effects of stigmatization and exclusion on self-perception, agency and voice. The chapter concludes with a number of evidence-based strategies for creating classrooms, schools and communities in which all are valued, welcomed and belong.

Keywords: Social inclusion; belonging; agency; social exclusion; stigma; disability; social structures

INTRODUCTION

Invite a group of children to imagine that in a week's time they will be moving to a new community and going to a new school. When asked what they need most on that first day of school, the answers are not surprising: someone to sit with at lunch, someone to say 'hi', to be invited to join a group, a smile of welcome — signs that this will be a place where they will 'fit in', be valued and included. And when asked to imagine what they would most want the students in the new school to know about them, responses might include 'that I'm nice', 'that I'm fun', 'that I'd be a good friend', 'that I'm worth getting to know' — comments supporting one's dignity and value.

Promoting Social Inclusion: Co-Creating Environments That Foster Equity and Belonging
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School is a social environment and when children feel rejected or are treated as outsiders — that is, when they question whether they are valued and belong — classroom participation and academic functioning can be affected, as well as their emotional well-being (Buhs, Ladd, & Herald, 2006). Social inclusion is essential in school, as it is in life. This chapter will explore the constructs of social inclusion, exclusion and belonging with regard to persons in general and more specifically children with disability. Evidence-based strategies to foster social inclusion and belonging will be reviewed with the goal of creating education and community environments where all are valued, welcomed and belong.

SOCIAL INCLUSION: A BASIC RIGHT AND PROVISION OF OPPORTUNITY

Inclusion is often focused on presence, such as placement in a general education classroom, attendance at a club, organizational or recreational event, or being in the workplace. Merely being present, though, does not guarantee social inclusion. It is highly possible to be situated in a classroom, workplace or community and still feel isolated, overlooked, marginalized or alone — that is, feeling as if perceived as ‘other’. Although present, there is no social inclusion.

Baumgartner and Burns (2014) point to a lack of consistency in the literature regarding the definition and components of social inclusion. This, they maintain, may be due to various conceptualizations of the construct. To illustrate, they present Huxley and colleagues’ two main ‘schools of thought’ regarding social inclusion. The ‘rights-based’ approach focuses on ways in which social exclusion deprives individuals with disability of their rights as full members of society. Social inclusion, thus, is deemed a basic right of all individuals. A second approach centres on the requisite development and provision of opportunities for persons with disabilities to access and engage in community and society, which Baumgartner and Burns (2014) suggest includes individual agency, control and choice regarding where, when and how to participate. Affirming social inclusion as both a basic right and a provision of opportunity for children with disabilities is clearly stipulated in Article 23.3 of the UN *Convention on the Rights of the Child*, which states that accessible and affordable protocols should be established and provided:

[...] to ensure that the disabled child has effective access to and receives education, training, healthcare services, rehabilitation services, preparation for employment and recreation opportunities in a manner conducive to the child’s achieving the fullest possible social integration and individual development [...]. (Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights, 1989)

The fundamental desire of individuals with disability is to achieve a sense of belonging within their communities (Hall, 2010). To belong, Hall suggests, ‘[...] is to feel attached, to feel valued, and to have a sense of insidership and proximity [...]’ (p. 56). For this reason, she has suggested replacing the term inclusion with belonging. Within the literature, however, the terms social inclusion and belonging often appear to be used interchangeably; that is, social inclusion typically incorporates belonging, and the criteria for belonging often overlap with

those suggested for social inclusion. What seems to be foundational in the literature is the essential role that both social inclusion and belonging play in personal well-being.

BELONGING: A UNIVERSAL HUMAN NEED

According to [Baumeister and Leary \(1995\)](#), '[...] the need to belong is a powerful, fundamental, and extremely pervasive motivation' (p. 497). Psychologists and sociologists have long agreed that the tendency to form and identify with social groups is an innate human trait, found across cultures and people groups, though differentiated by individual and cultural variations and expressions ([Baumeister & Leary, 1995](#); [Bennett, 2014](#)). [Baumeister and Leary's \(1995\)](#) 'belongingness hypothesis' is situated in studies examining a number of universal components of human interaction patterns, including the following: (1) the natural propensity to form social bonds and groupings that promote identity and affiliation, (2) the predisposition to preserve, or resist dissolution of, meaningful social bonds, (3) the tendency to engage in ongoing and at times considerable cognitive processing to understand and make sense of interpersonal relationships and interactions, (4) the expression of strong emotions, both positive and negative, associated with belonging and inclusion and (5) the negative effects experienced when group belonging or affiliation is absent, dissipates or is lost. These components were further explored in the study by [Gere and MacDonald's \(2010\)](#) more recent examination of research in support of belongingness theory, leading them to conclude ' [...] the need to belong has strong effects on people's cognitions, emotions, and behaviors, and a chronically unmet need has many negative consequences that can profoundly affect an individual's life' (p. 110).

Belonging involves moving beyond stereotypes and societal narratives about disability to being accepted for who one is. Having to change, that is, to become someone or something else, in order to be included is not belonging ([Scorgie & Sobsey, 2017](#)). Rather belonging implies acceptance without judgement, being treated equally and having voice ([Hall, 2009](#)). It emphasizes a focus on an individual's interests, strengths and abilities rather than on deficiencies. It also suggests the right of persons to craft and own their unique identity and that others view them as they wish to be viewed or as they view themselves. For example, in a study with teens with disability, [Robinson and colleagues \(2018\)](#) concluded:

when young people felt there was congruence between how they saw themselves and the way that other people related to them, they felt valued and understood – known in a positive way. (p. 8)

This implies being regarded holistically as a unique person, rather than labelled by perceived shortcomings or deficiencies. Since belonging is so essential to well-being, it is important to examine how social inclusion and belonging might be fostered in school and community settings.

SOCIAL INCLUSION: INTERPERSONAL, SCHOOL AND COMMUNITY STRUCTURES

In her research with families, [Boss \(2006, 2007\)](#) suggested family membership incorporates two components – physical, that is those who are members by birth or marriage, and psychological, that is those members who are valued, wanted and celebrated. Boss suggested that to be a nominal member of a family, yet marginalized, devalued or treated as if unwanted produces ‘membership ambiguity’, that is, the perception of who is considered ‘in’ and who is ‘out’, which can initiate and perpetuate personal and family stress. Boss’ concept has been widened to incorporate various types of groups or communities, including the experiences of individuals with disability and their family members, extending an understanding of the key role of the psychological component of group membership and inclusion.

[Baumgartner and Burns \(2014\)](#) suggest that social inclusion occurs when an individual ‘[...] feels and experiences a sense of belonging to, identification with and acceptance by’ their community and society as well as the opportunity to choose the groups or communities with which one desires affiliation and to function within them as one determines (p. 362). Research offers a number of key components of belonging and social inclusion when considering children, youth and young adults with disability.

School inclusion occurs when ‘[...] all students, including students with disabilities, are full members of the school community and entitled to equal access to social and academic opportunities’ ([McMahon, Keys, Berardi, Crouch, & Coker, 2016](#), p. 657). Inclusion, therefore, accords each child value and worth. Through their research on social inclusion of students with disability, based on a study of 11 schools in urban areas with diverse populations in the USA, [McMahon and colleagues \(2016\)](#) found that social inclusion, or the opportunity to connect with peers both inside and outside of the classroom, was associated with greater academic achievement and school belonging (i.e. perceptions of acceptance, valuing and connection). Similarly, in a study of youth with intellectual disability in three small town communities in Australia, [Robinson and colleagues \(2018\)](#) observed that being ‘recognized, valued and welcome’ were reported by the participants as central to feelings of belonging (p. 8).

Belonging and acceptance also incorporate relationships that are reciprocal, through interactions that involve both giving and receiving, with each person viewed as having something to contribute that is valued by others or a role to play that enriches all ([Ferguson, 2010; Hall, 2009](#)). Belonging, therefore, requires environments and interactions situated in safety and trust, where all children are supported, can be authentic, explore possibilities, learn, grow and become ([Robinson, Fisher, Hill, & Graham, 2018; Shogren et al., 2015](#)).

Belonging further implies agency and choice regarding inclusion in the groups or communities that are most relevant and meaningful to them. For some individuals, this includes the choice, or self-selection, to engage with peers with disability ([Salmon, 2013](#)). The rationale underlying agency and choice may be important considerations here. For example, [Robinson et al. \(2018\)](#) indicated

that some young people with disabilities in their study decided to self-excluded due to feeling uncomfortable, fearful or uncertainty of how to act in certain settings, or to avoid being hurt (p. 15). [Salmon \(2013\)](#) also suggested that the experience of labelling, stereotyping, separation and status loss caused some students with disability to seek friendship with similar others through self-exclusion. These two examples present a type of exclusion that was imposed, based on inability to access or lack of welcome into a particular group. However, Salmon also described teens who ‘[...] felt a greater sense of belonging when with peers who shared the disability experience (cf. Marcus, 2005), thus self-exclusion was a viable strategy for creating sustaining friendships in the context of stigma’ (p. 254). In other words, disability created a bond of understanding or ‘kinship’ (p. 353). The justifications underlying personal choice of community, according to Salmon, are key when considering self-exclusion; self-selection involves personal agency and choice, while being segregated by others is discriminatory.

Students with disabilities who feel a sense of social inclusion and belonging within the school environment demonstrate higher academic achievement and more positive perceptions of school ([McMahon et al., 2016](#)). They also generally value being in classrooms with their peers and desire to build friendships ([Shogren et al., 2015](#)).

Though social inclusion has been viewed as essential to well-being and achievement, research suggests that both adults and children with disabilities report experiences of exclusion that have caused them to wonder whether they ‘belong’ ([Hall, 2009](#); [Mathias, Kermode, San Sebastian, Koschorke, & Goicolea, 2015](#); [Salmon, 2013](#)). Since the experience of social exclusion has been demonstrated to have negative consequences, it is essential to recognize, understand and address social exclusion, and the processes that may lead to it.

SOCIAL EXCLUSION AND DISABILITY

From a very early age, humans are ‘highly sensitive to exclusion’ ([Bennett, 2014](#), p.183). Studies have demonstrated both emotional and behavioural responses to the experience of exclusion. For example, [Gere and MacDonald \(2010\)](#) report that individuals who have experienced exclusion have displayed emotional responses of anger, sadness, shame and embarrassment. Reactions to exclusion may include increased use of connection seeking behaviours to form new relationships or, alternately, actions that further reduce the probability of connection, such as retaliation or attributing negative intent to those who have engaged in excluding.

[Killen, Mulvey, and Hitti \(2013\)](#) have explored the experience of social exclusion in children, examining research focused on both interpersonal rejection and intergroup exclusion. Interpersonal rejection is typically centred in individual differences, behaviours or traits that are used to justify the exclusion of another, such as children who appear vulnerable or are aggressive. Rationale for rejection is attributed to intra-personal attributes or a perceived deficit in the child. Intergroup exclusion is centred on ‘prejudicial attitudes’ towards those representative of a group identifier, such as race, gender, nationality or ethnicity

(p. 772). When rationale for exclusion is based on criteria over which an individual or group has limited or no control, such as disability, this can result in perceptions that one may have limited agency or opportunity to belong (Baglieri, Bejoian, Broderick, Conner, & Valle, 2011; Bennett, 2014). Since research suggests children begin to form group identities and affiliations in early childhood, in-group biases, attributions and ways of perceiving others can lead to distancing and exclusion with long-term implications for social belonging (Buhs et al., 2006; Killen et al., 2013).

Four interrelated components that result in stigma and that may contribute to or be used to justify exclusion have been identified by Link and Phelan (2001). The first component involves labelling the other as 'different' based on criteria or categories that are deemed salient to the individual or group. The second component, stereotyping, involves attributing a negative association or tag to the attribute or characteristic that denotes difference. In the third component, the negative characterization is utilized to justified separation – conceptualizing 'us' and 'them'. Depersonalization can occur when the individual or group is identified by or described using the label. Finally, status loss and discrimination result when individuals or group members are allocated a lower place within a social hierarchy, which is then used to create assumptions and expectations that affect opportunity to access services such as education, employment, housing and health care.

The experience of labelling can also have psychological and emotional implications if the negative associations, attitudes and expectations are internalized, resulting in lower self-understanding, self-esteem and self-efficacy and in self-blame (Link & Phelan, 2001; Watermeyer & Swartz, 2016). In addition, the denial of the rights and opportunities accorded to others can trigger feelings of emotional 'trauma' which can produce ongoing psychological pain (Watermeyer & Swartz, 2016, p. 270). Link and Phelan (2001) highlight the 'power dimension' of the stigma process, for it is those who possess social, economic, cultural or political power who are able to ascribe stigma to others (p. 375) that can propagate inequality and limit access, opportunity and belonging.

Stigma can also be a key driver of social exclusion for persons with disability. In a study examining social exclusion of 13 people with mental disorders and eight caregivers in two rural communities in northern India, Mathias et al. (2015) found that experiences with stigmatism often included feelings of distancing, being disregarded, loss of agency and valuing, encountering negative perceptions of ability, and feelings of unworthiness.

Social exclusion of children with disabilities often incorporates the components of stigma described by Link and Phelan (2001). For example, Nowicki, Brown, and Stepien (2014) investigated the issues relating to social exclusion of students with intellectual or learning disabilities in inclusive classrooms (Grades 5 and 6) across five schools in Ontario, Canada. The overarching theme regarding exclusion was 'difference', described as 'negative perceptions of physical characteristics, behaviours, learning abilities and resource allocation' (p. 355). Not all justifications for exclusion, however, were based on stigma; some

included lack of knowledge, concern about navigating challenging emotions or behaviours, or differences in ability, interests or activity choices between children with disabilities and their peers. Research suggests that the tendency of children to preference 'in-group members' over 'out-group members' may result in a form of passive neglecting rather than an overt rejection of others (Bennett, 2014).

In another Canadian study, exploring ways in which adolescents with disabilities negotiate stigma, Salmon (2013) found that while each student shared positive accounts of inclusion, all described experiences of rejection by mid-to-late elementary grades based on negative perceptions of disability. Students reported that being teased, mocked and receiving derogatory messages and comments resulted in feelings of increased separation and social isolation from peers. Shogren et al.'s (2015) study of six schools known for strong inclusive practices found that bullying was experienced by students with disabilities, but more often in areas of the school that were less regulated, such as the playground, bathroom or the bus, demonstrating that social inclusion must incorporate multiple contexts and formats to be fully effectual.

Research has indicated a basic human need for belonging. It has also underscored the negative consequences associated with rejection and exclusion. Social inclusion and belonging are complex and multifaceted constructs that interweave the experiences of children and adults with disability on a day-to-day basis (McMahon et al., 2016). It is, therefore, critical to identify evidence-based strategies that might be employed by educators, community and organizational personnel and those in the workplace to foster the co-creation of environments where all feel included and belonging.

STRATEGIES TO PROMOTE SOCIAL INCLUSION AND BELONGING

Social inclusion and belonging are vital for optimal school and life outcomes for all. The co-creation of environments that foster social inclusion should, therefore, include the involvement of all participants. In schools and community locations where children interact, this requires that all students are engaged, both those with and those without disabilities. This might involve the courage to challenge the structure of a community moving from segregation and exclusion to equity and inclusion. Research suggests several key strategies for promoting social inclusion and belonging. The following seven approaches are proffered as useful guidelines for commencing a strategic approach to improving social inclusion for students with disability through a sense of belonging, established by co-creating positive school environments.

Create Opportunities to Interact with Peers

Research suggests that attitudes towards others are formed within a context (Killen et al., 2013). Therefore, children who have opportunity to interact with

others in diverse groupings may demonstrate greater acceptance of and lower prejudice towards others. For example, [Papageorgiou, Andreou, and Soulis \(2008\)](#) described a 10-week pilot programme to include three children with multiple disabilities and visual impairment who were in a special school in an art programme at a mainstream school designed to develop group working, collaboration and creativity with the goal of promoting positive attitudes and friendships and to enable students to feel more comfortable interacting and sharing with one another. The results demonstrated that students gained more positive perceptions of the inclusion experience and others in the programme, and students with disabilities indicated a desire to attend the mainstream school.

Opportunities to interact and participate around common interests and goals create safe spaces that allow students to focus on similarities, abilities and strengths, rather than differences. [Hall \(2010\)](#) describes two theatre arts programmes in Scotland in which persons with intellectual disability engaged their strengths and interests through opportunities to perform in various venues. Being identified as 'actors' or 'artists' accorded each participant a more authentic identity as well as provided a venue for interaction and friendship formation with others with and without disability. The 'safe spaces' of the rehearsal rooms and a café designed to promote interactions enabled the development of personal self-confidence and positive self-identity (p. 55). To this end, educators might find ways to openly recognize, value and celebrate the strengths, talents and abilities of each member of the school community.

Identify and Address the Barriers to Social Inclusion

Barriers to social inclusion can incorporate both physical and relational aspects. For example, students may have little opportunity to relate when they are placed in segregated school environments or when participation in after school or community clubs, activities or programmes with those of shared interests is limited. Effective social inclusion requires the ability to embrace change and a willingness to commit to and engage in interventions with the goal of enhancing participation of all for the benefit of all. [Shogren et al. \(2015\)](#) suggest that school belonging should incorporate 'high expectations, feeling supported to meet those expectations, and feeling connected to teachers and peers' (p. 248). This involves both teachers' and students' understanding, acceptance and incorporation of supports and accommodations that facilitate inclusion, as a validation of the uniqueness of each individual. This also respects multiple means of learning and representation, activities that foster engagement and expression that allows choice and is viewed as beneficial for all.

Emphasize Reciprocity

The perception of reciprocity, that is of being an active contributor, or of having input that is valued by and enriches all, validates each individual and is central to a sense of belonging ([Ferguson, 2010](#)). This may not always be achieved through groupings or pairings of students with and without disability. For

example, [Shogren et al.'s \(2015\)](#) study of inclusive schools found that though students without disabilities described positive aspects of interaction with peers with disability, they viewed themselves more as 'a facilitator of help and support', rather than as a reciprocal participant (p. 250). The experience of reciprocity, thus, may require the design of more structured activities in which students' individual strengths are highlighted. Activities should enable opportunities for each student to provide input into the creation of a project or outcome. Roles should be chosen or designated to promote the participation and contribution of each group member.

Promote Values, Rights and Character Traits that Support Social Inclusion

When crafting classroom rules and standards for behaviour, students are more likely to feel ownership if they have voice in designing the protocols. More important than stating behavioural expectations is the need to identify the underlying rationale for the protocols, often based in concepts such as justice, tolerance, dignity, respect and personal rights as a member of the classroom and school.

Children might be asked to reflect on moral considerations such as who might be hurt, affected or experience rejection given a specific behaviour or protocol ([Killen et al., 2013](#)) or reflect on taking an empathic approach where they imagine themselves in a particular scenario, such as the sample scenario that begins this chapter, and determine how they would feel and what they would most need at the time. Identifying shared needs and desires for social inclusion can introduce opportunities to recognize examples of both exclusion and inclusion within a classroom or school environment that can facilitate understanding, choice and behavioural change.

Values and character traits can also be explored through students identifying their perception of their rights as individuals, how they would like to be treated, what character traits they would like to own and display, the values connected to the traits selected and specific actions indicative of individual personal values and traits. Children might also examine how the display of values and character attributes benefits both the school community and themselves and explore their own psychosocial growth and development.

Examine the Social Structures of the School and Community

[Killen et al. \(2013\)](#) differentiate between interpersonal rejection and intergroup exclusion. Interpersonal rejection is typically addressed through social skills training as well as the personal values and character traits addressed in the previous section. With intergroup exclusion, a different approach is needed that focuses on social structures within an environment and the impact on belonging and inclusion. As proposed by [Killen et al. \(2013\)](#), "Understanding social hierarchies involves obtaining information about the larger social structure that creates a majority and minority status within the peer world" (p. 784). This incorporates determining who has access to power, prestige and influence, within a social group and how these resources might be used to benefit some members

and marginalize others. As students examine the school environment, they might ask questions such as who is valued and what are the criteria for valuing? and who is marginalized and what is the justification for marginalization? (Scorgie, 2015).

Students might also explore the concept of stigma reflecting on ways that power structures can lead to labelling, stereotyping, separation and status loss and how these actions are experienced in society and within the school (Link & Phelan, 2001). Exploring societal conceptions and valuations of various characteristics, such as independence and interdependence, might enable greater recognition of how perceptions of individuals are situated in societal attitudes and beliefs about ability and in traits that are deemed important (Watermeyer & Swartz, 2016). Students might also explore attributions of difference with respect to disability, examining how ‘multiple and intersecting social systems focus on impairment rather than relationships, capability and individuality’ (Robinson et al., 2018, p. 17).

Utilize a Whole-school Approach

Achieving social inclusion can occur within an interpersonal, small-group, activity-oriented or classroom atmosphere. The more effective securing of belonging, nonetheless, occurs when a whole-school commitment and initiative is undertaken. McMahon et al. (2016) offer an ecological framework to incorporate a whole-school focus on inclusion across four domains:

- (1) *Organizational inclusion* involves the activity of school leadership to promote belonging through modelling inclusive actions and attitudes, providing staff development, implementing school improvement plans and making sure that students and teachers have access to the services and resources needed.
- (2) *Academic inclusion* promotes the active participation of students with disabilities in learning activities with peers to the greatest extent possible, utilizing appropriate practices, pedagogy, materials and supports required to assure access to learning environments and activities.
- (3) *Assessment and planning* comprise gaining knowledge of each student’s strengths, goals and areas for growth and developing interventions and educational plans incorporating interests and strengths.
- (4) *Social inclusion* incorporates opportunities and supports to enable students with disability to connect with their peers to the fullest extent desired both inside and outside of the classroom.

Through data collected to assess the framework, McMahon et al. (2016) found that organizational inclusion and effective assessment and planning protocols were associated with school satisfaction and belonging and that perceptions of social inclusion were associated with higher academic achievement and a greater sense of belonging.

Educators should also model valuing and inclusion through their interactions with students within the classroom. For example, Loreman’s (2011) pedagogy through love highlighted the importance of demonstrating kindness and

empathy, intimacy and bonding, sacrifice and forgiveness, and acceptance and community, the key components of inclusion and belonging.

Attend to Voice

The disability community has embraced the tenet ‘Nothing about us without us’. Far too often, the non-disabled have been positioned to make decisions for and to speak on behalf of persons with disability, with limited input from those for whom decisions are being made. Shogren et al.’s (2015) study of inclusive schools, however, found that all students, those with and without disabilities, desired to be self-determined learners and were knowledgeable about and able to communicate the supports and strategies that were most effective for them as learners. Educators, therefore, need to attend to all voices. Whitehurst (2006) suggested that the debate about ‘whose perceptions are legitimate’ continues, shaping understanding of who is empowered to make decisions for whom (p. 56). She and others have called for utilizing unique and individualized methods to elicit voice from those who are so often silent and underrepresented in decision-making. To that end, she concludes her discussion of securing inclusive practices for children with disabilities with the following:

Children are children first—we need their voices to inform our practice. We need to ensure that the voices, which have for so long remained silent, reach us, inform our practice and create a way of working which takes everyone’s view into account. Only then can we say we are truly working inclusively.

Whitehurst (2006, p. 60)

CONCLUSION

Creating schools and communities in which all members are active and willing partners is essential to ensure an inclusive approach that fosters social inclusion and a strong sense of belonging. The process to achieve this may involve the need to explore the social structure of a community and examine barriers to belonging such as suppression of agency and a tendency to categorize individuals according to difference that leads to marginalization and exclusion. While this may commence at a whole-school level, it can also begin from the ground up, as educators and students claim power to shape their own communities, to determine how they relate to one another and to become agents of change. Belonging happens when there is a shift in perspective, from a focus on difference to one centred in shared values, acceptance and affirming the dignity and worth of all.

Social inclusion involves a systems approach, but it can also start in one school that makes a commitment to secure belonging for all, or one teacher who recognizes and highlights the strengths of each student and who is open to exploring innovative and inclusive approaches and embraces differentiated strategies that allow all to participate. It can come from just one student who chooses to say ‘hi’, who welcomes another into an activity or group and who focuses on similarities between peers, rather than on differences. Social inclusion

can begin with a parent who chooses to advocate for the rights of his or her child, or a child who stands up and claims voice, not allowing others to define him or her or to determine possibilities. To be effectual, social inclusion requires a posture of listening, of learning, of looking both inward and outward and of leaning into change. When that happens, individuals and the communities to which they belong can begin to affirm validation, agency and voice for all through a positive and embracing school community embedded within an inclusive environment.

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